KINGDOM LIFE MINISTRY

Clean Out the Leaven

The Feast of Unleavened Bread: Seven Days to Walk Out of Egypt

A Midrash Study on Chag HaMatzot, Leviticus 23:6-8

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah restored. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Passover gets Israel out of Egypt in one night. Unleavened Bread spends seven days getting Egypt out of Israel.

YHWH told his people to search their houses and remove every trace of leaven, then eat unleavened bread for a full week. Paul says the same feast is still kept today, **not with old yeast, neither with the yeast of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth**.

HOW TO READ THIS HANDOUT

Commanded means the instruction is written plainly. **Interpretive** means a reasonable reading Scripture does not state outright. **Conviction** means it is how we at Kingdom Life walk it out. Where Scripture stops speaking, we do not call our reading a commandment.

SECTION I

The Appointed Time Itself

> *On the fifteenth day of the same month is the feast of unleavened bread to YHWH. Seven days you shall eat unleavened bread. In the first day you shall have a holy convocation. You shall do no regular work. But you shall offer an offering made by fire to YHWH seven days. In the seventh day is a holy convocation: you shall do no regular work.*
> **LEVITICUS 23:6-8**

Passover is the fourteenth. Unleavened Bread begins the next day, the fifteenth, and runs seven days through the twenty first (Exodus 12:18). The first and the seventh days are each a *miqra qodesh*, a holy convocation, and on both no regular work is done. These are the high Sabbaths of the spring. John calls the first of them a high day (John 19:31). **Commanded.**

> *You shall observe the feast of unleavened bread; for in this same day I have brought your armies out of the land of Egypt. Therefore you shall observe this day throughout your generations by an ordinance forever.*
> **EXODUS 12:17**

The Words

- ***Chag (H2282).*** A feast, from *chagag*, to keep a festival. Unleavened Bread is one of the three *chaggim* when Israel appeared before YHWH (Exodus 23:14-17).
- ***Matzah (H4682).*** Unleavened bread, bread made without leaven. The feast is *Chag HaMatzot*, the feast of unleavened breads.
- ***Chametz (H2557).*** Leavened bread, anything that has been leavened. From *chamets*, to be sour, to be leavened.
- ***Se'or (H7603).*** Leaven itself, the sour starter that leavens a lump. Exodus 12:15 says to remove the *se'or* from your houses, and Exodus 13:7 says neither *chametz* nor *se'or* is to be seen.
- ***Azymos (G106).*** The Greek for unleavened, used in the Septuagint for this feast and in the New Testament for the days of Unleavened Bread (Acts 12:3; 20:6) and for the believer: you are *azymoi*, unleavened (1 Corinthians 5:7).
- ***Zyme (G2219).*** Leaven, yeast. Yahshua uses it for the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees and for hypocrisy (Matthew 16:6, 12; Luke 12:1).
- ***Lechem oni.*** The bread of affliction (Deuteronomy 16:3). Unleavened bread remembers the haste of leaving Egypt, when there was no time for dough to rise (Exodus 12:39).

SECTION II

Why Leaven? Out of Egypt in Haste

> *You shall eat no leavened bread with it. You shall eat unleavened bread with it seven days, even the bread of affliction; for you came out of the land of Egypt in haste; that you may remember the day when you came out of the land of Egypt all the days of your life.*
> **DEUTERONOMY 16:3**

The first reason Scripture gives is history. Israel was driven out of Egypt so fast that they carried their dough before it was leavened, kneading troughs bound up in their clothes on their shoulders, and baked unleavened cakes on the way (Exodus 12:34, 39). The bread of the feast is the bread of people who did not have time to settle into Egypt one more day.

The second reason is what leaven does. A little leaven works its way through the whole lump (Galatians 5:9; 1 Corinthians 5:6). It is a slow, quiet, invisible change that eventually takes over everything it touches. That is why Scripture uses it as a picture of sin, false teaching, and pride. **Stated in the text by Yahshua and Paul.**

SECTION III

Search the House

> *Seven days you shall eat unleavened bread; even the first day you shall put away yeast out of your houses, for whoever eats leavened bread from the first day until the seventh day, that soul shall be cut off from Israel.*
> **EXODUS 12:15**

> *There shall be no yeast found in your houses for seven days, for whoever eats that which is leavened, that soul shall be cut off from the congregation of Israel, whether he be a foreigner, or one who is born in the land.*
> **EXODUS 12:19**

Look at the end of Exodus 12:19. The instruction to remove leaven names **the foreigner**, the *ger*, right beside the native born. This feast was never for one bloodline only. **Commanded.**

Exodus 13:7 goes further: no leavened bread is to be seen with you, and no leaven seen with you **within all your borders**. Scripture tells us what to remove and where it must not be found. It does not tell us how to search. The house is cleared of leaven and leavened bread before the fifteenth begins, and unleavened bread is eaten through the seven days (Exodus 12:18; 13:6-7). **Commanded.**

WHAT COUNTS AS LEAVEN

Scripture names the leavening agent (*se'or*) and leavened bread (*chametz*). In plain terms: yeast, sourdough starter, and bread or baked goods that have been leavened.

Many households also remove baking soda and baking powder, since they make dough rise. That is a reasonable application, but Scripture does not name chemical leaveners. **Interpretive.** Do what you are convinced of, and do not bind your conviction on your brother.

SECTION IV

The Leaven Inside: What Yahshua and Paul Said It Means

> *Yahshua said to them, "Take heed and beware of the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees."*
> **MATTHEW 16:6**

The disciples thought he was talking about bread. Matthew says they finally understood that he was warning them about **the teaching** of the Pharisees and Sadducees (16:12). In Luke he names the leaven of the Pharisees as **hypocrisy** (Luke 12:1), and in Mark he adds the leaven of Herod (Mark 8:15). Yahshua used the feast's own picture to teach his disciples what to search for in themselves.

Puffed Up: Paul on Pride

Paul writes to Corinth about a man living in open sin, and he does not start with the man. He starts with the assembly: **You are puffed up** (1 Corinthians 5:2). The Greek word is *physioo* (G5448), to inflate, to blow up like air in dough. Then in verse 6: **Your boasting is not good. Don't you know that a little yeast leavens the whole lump?** Their pride was the leaven that let the sin sit there unaddressed.

Paul uses the same word again: knowledge **puffs up**, but love builds up (1 Corinthians 8:1). And love **is not puffed up** (1 Corinthians 13:4). The opposite of leaven is not knowledge. It is love.

> *Purge out the old yeast, that you may be a new lump, even as you are unleavened. For indeed Messiah, our Passover, has been sacrificed in our place. Therefore let's keep the feast, not with old yeast, neither with the yeast of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.*
> **1 CORINTHIANS 5:7-8**

Notice the order. **You are unleavened** because the Passover has been sacrificed. Then **purge out the old yeast**. We do not clean ourselves up to be accepted. We were accepted through the blood, and now we clean house because of who we are. The word for sincerity, *eilikrineia* (G1505), describes something pure and unmixed, nothing hidden inside.

> **THE ROOT UNDER THE LEAVEN**
>
> At Kingdom Life we hold that **pride is the root of unforgiveness**, and that pride hides itself inside other sins. That is exactly how leaven works: small, quiet, and working through the whole lump before anyone sees it. **Conviction, drawn from 1 Corinthians 5:2, 6 and James 4:6.**
>
> So when you search your house this year, search your heart with it. Where are you puffed up? Who have you refused to forgive because you were right? That is the leaven that ruins the whole lump.

SECTION V

The Bread of Life

Yahshua said, **I am the bread of life** (John 6:35), the living bread which came down out of heaven (John 6:51). He was born in Bethlehem, whose name means house of bread. He was laid in the tomb as the feast of Unleavened Bread began, and his body did not see corruption (Psalm 16:10; Acts 2:31). Leaven is a picture of corruption working through a lump; the body of Messiah lay in the grave and was untouched by it. **The Psalm 16 point is stated in the text; the link to unleavened bread is interpretive.**

That is why Paul can say **you are unleavened**. The believer's new life is joined to the one who had no sin in him (1 John 3:5; 2 Corinthians 5:21). The seven days of eating unleavened bread are a week of eating the picture of who he is and who he is making us.

SECTION VI

Keeping Unleavened Bread Without the Temple

Leviticus 23:8 commands an offering made by fire all seven days. Deuteronomy 16:16 says three times a year all the males shall appear before YHWH **in the place which he chooses**: at the feast of unleavened bread, the feast of weeks, and the feast of tents. There is no altar and no chosen place standing today, so those parts cannot be done, and we do not invent substitutes for them (Deuteronomy 12:13-14). **Commanded, and honestly unkeepable right now.**

But look at how much of this feast lives in the house, not the temple:

- **Remove leaven from your houses.** The instruction is aimed at houses and borders, not the sanctuary (Exodus 12:15, 19; 13:7). **Commanded.**
- **Eat unleavened bread seven days.** (Exodus 12:15, 18; 13:6; Leviticus 23:6). **Commanded.**
- **Rest on the first and seventh days.** No regular work on either holy convocation (Leviticus 23:7-8). **Commanded.**

- **Gather on the first and seventh days.** A *miqra qodesh* is a holy calling together, from *qara*, to call or proclaim. Read the Word together, worship, pray. **Commanded** as a gathering; Scripture does not script it.
- **Tell your children.** You shall tell your son in that day, it is because of that which YHWH did for me when I came out of Egypt (Exodus 13:8). **Commanded.**
- **Purge the leaven of malice and wickedness.** (1 Corinthians 5:7-8). **Commanded** to believers far from Jerusalem.

The Apostles Kept the Calendar Outside the Land

Paul wrote **let's keep the feast** to a mostly Gentile assembly in Corinth (1 Corinthians 5:8). Luke, traveling with Paul, marks time by this feast while they were in Macedonia: **We sailed away from Philippi after the days of Unleavened Bread** (Acts 20:6). The apostles did not stop knowing what season it was when they left the land.

And YHWH said of his scattered people, **I will be to them a sanctuary for a little while in the countries where they have come** (Ezekiel 11:16). Wherever the house of Israel is scattered, and wherever the grafted in branches grow, the feast can be kept in the house.

SECTION VII

Grafted In: A Feast for the Foreigner Too

Exodus 12:19 names the foreigner in the very instruction to remove leaven. Exodus 12:49 says one instruction for the native born and the stranger. Numbers 15:15-16 repeats it: one statute for you and for the stranger, forever throughout your generations, as you are, so the foreigner shall be before YHWH.

Gentiles who come to Messiah are grafted into the olive tree and share in its root and richness (Romans 11:17). Those who were once far off are brought near by the blood of Messiah, no longer strangers but fellow citizens with the holy ones (Ephesians 2:13, 19). If you have been brought out of Egypt by the Lamb, the seven days that follow the Lamb are yours to keep.

SECTION VIII

What We Leave Out and Why

Rabbinic tradition has built a large set of rules around this feast: the ceremonial search for leaven by candlelight with a feather and spoon on the night before, the legal selling of leavened goods to a Gentile so they can stay in the house, special supervised matzah, and lists of forbidden grains and legumes. None of that is written in Scripture.

Selling leaven on paper to keep it in the house is the opposite of what the text says, which is to **put it away** so it is not seen (Exodus 12:15; 13:7). Yahshua warned against setting aside the commandment of Elohim to keep a tradition (Mark 7:9). We keep the instruction, and we let it be as simple as he wrote it.

SECTION IX

Walking It Out

1. **Clean in the days before.** Remove yeast, sourdough starter, and leavened bread and baked goods from your house and car before the fifteenth begins at sunset.
2. **Make it a family search.** Let the children help. As each item goes out, talk about what leaven pictures, and pray about what needs to go out of your hearts.
3. **Stock unleavened bread.** Flour, water, oil, and salt make simple flatbread. Eat some every day of the seven, as the instruction says.
4. **Rest and gather on the first day.** No regular work. Read Exodus 12 and 13 and 1 Corinthians 5 together.
5. **Search one area of the heart each day.** Pride, malice, hypocrisy, unforgiveness, false teaching, bitterness, and fear of man are seven worth starting with.
6. **Forgive before the seventh day.** Let the week end with nothing sour left in you toward anyone.
7. **Rest and gather on the seventh day.** Close the feast with worship and thanksgiving for the one who brought you out.

SECTION X

Cross Reference Index

Primary texts: Leviticus 23:6-8; Exodus 12:15-20; Exodus 13:3-10; Deuteronomy 16:3-8; 1 Corinthians 5:6-8

Out of Egypt in haste: Exodus 12:33-39; Deuteronomy 16:3

Removing leaven: Exodus 12:15, 19; Exodus 13:7; Exodus 23:18; Exodus 34:25

Leaven as teaching and hypocrisy: Matthew 16:6-12; Mark 8:15; Luke 12:1

Leaven as pride and sin: 1 Corinthians 5:1-8; 1 Corinthians 8:1; 1 Corinthians 13:4; Galatians 5:7-9; James 4:6

The bread of life: John 6:32-51; Psalm 16:10; Acts 2:27-31; 1 John 3:5; 2 Corinthians 5:21

High days: Leviticus 23:7-8; Exodus 12:16; John 19:31

Outside the land: Acts 12:3; Acts 20:6; Ezekiel 11:16; Deuteronomy 12:13-14; Deuteronomy 16:16

The stranger and the grafted in: Exodus 12:19, 49; Numbers 15:15-16; Romans 11:17-24; Ephesians 2:12-19

Tradition and Scripture: Mark 7:6-9; Deuteronomy 4:2

NOTES

Personal Notes and Convictions

Kingdom Life Ministry
Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.